

Picking Up the LEFTOVERS

The battered Left Front shifts into sop gear to woo minorities and tribals for the next poll battle

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BHATTACHARYA AT A LEFT RALLY



| By Abhijit Dasgupta |

The Left Front Government is not taking any chances after the drubbing it got in the Lok Sabha elections when Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress rolled all over it to win 19 seats in the state. With the more recent panchayat elections leaving the Left on even shakier ground and Assembly elections slated for 2011, Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya and Left Front Chairman Biman Bose are busy devising strategies to take on Banerjee.

Bhattacharya has taken it upon

himself to reach out to the minorities and tribals. He has ordered the modernisation of at least 60,000 madrasas in the state, taking them out of the purview of the Ministry of Higher Education and putting them under that of the Minorities Welfare Department to ensure that they are better looked after. A sum of Rs 68 crore has been set aside just for the madrasas. All this came only after the Muslims distanced themselves from the Left Front Government, which has always considered them an assured votebank.

In another move to appease Muslims, the state Government has

decided to make the Waqf Board fully computerised to cut down on paperwork for volumes of files and correspondence. Ali Biswas, CEO of the board, says, "We are taking help from the Delhi-based National Informatics Centre to work out the final operational system. By the end of this year, the Waqf operations will be fully computerised in Bengal."

After the Lalgargh fiasco, the Left cannot count on the tribal votebank any longer. To undo some of the damage, the state Education Ministry has issued instructions that tribal languages should form the main medium of instruction in schools in